

Game analysis

HOLLOW KNIGHT

Game type

- ❖ 2D
- ❖ Metroidvania
- ❖ Action-adventure

Game mechanics

Basic movement:

- ❖ Walk
- ❖ Jump
- ❖ Swimming
- ❖ Bouncing

Advanced movement:

- All these abilities are **unlocked** grabbing an item or defeating a boss
- ❖ Dash
- ❖ Super dash
- ❖ Double jump
- ❖ Wall climbing

Souls:

- 2 levels of **depth**: Can be used for healing (Focus) or cast spells
- ❖ Spells
 - Focus
 - Vengeful spirit
 - Desolated dive
 - Howling wraiths
 - Shade souls
 - Descending dark
 - Abyss shriek

Nail:

- ❖ Nail attack
- ❖ Nail arts
 - Cyclone slash
 - Dash slash
 - Great slash
- ❖ Reject projectiles

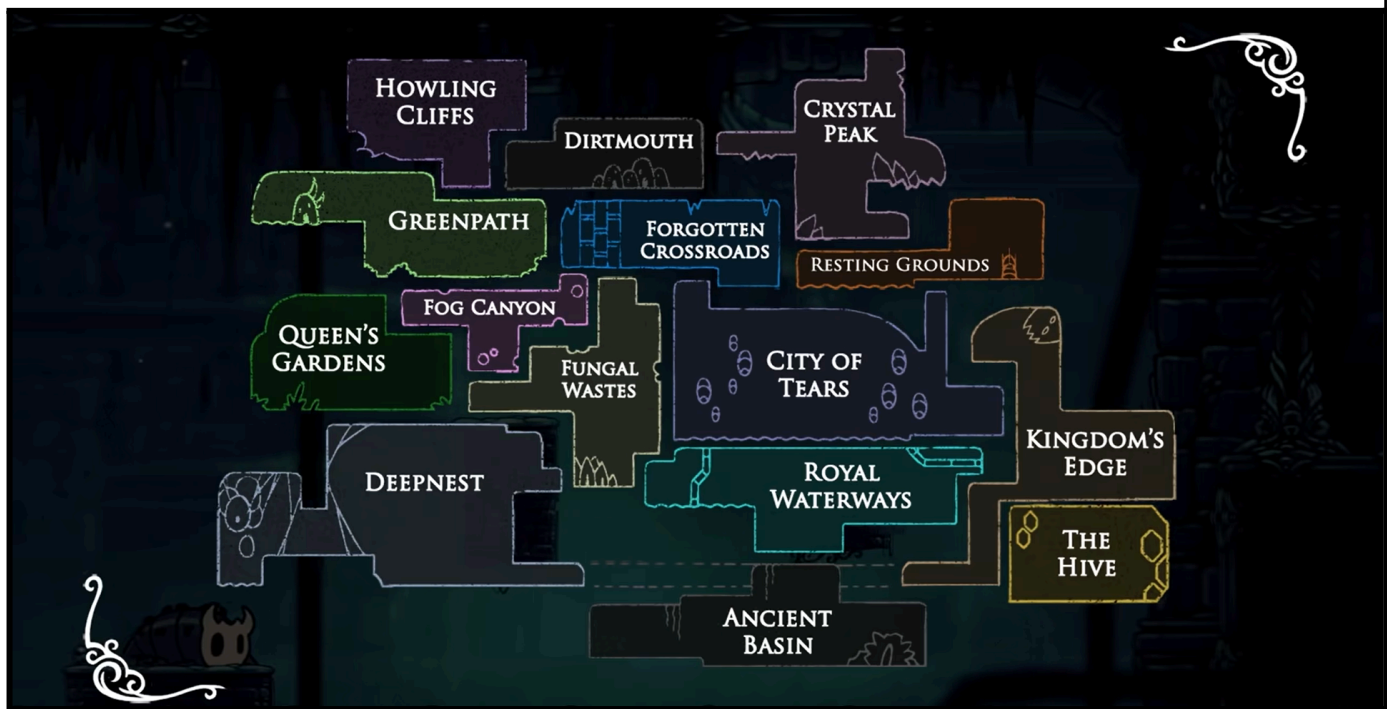
Inventory:

- ❖ Charms
- ❖ Upgrades
- ❖ Tradables
 - Can be turned to Npcs for Geo or other services

World:

- ❖ Dialogues
- ❖ Maps
- ❖ Benches
- ❖ Stags

World design



The game starts with the character jumping down from the **Howling Cliffs to Dirtmouth**. From there he can proceed to the **Forgotten Crossroads**, which are connected with Greenpath, the Fungal Wastes, Crystal Peak, the Fog Canyon, the Resting Grounds and the City of Tears.

Each area is distinct by a **specific color**, and there is no confusion among them. The map maintains the same colors, helping the player to navigate. Also different areas are characterized by **different aspects of gameplay and unique enemies**:

- ❖ **Crystal peak**: Dodging laser beams
- ❖ **Fungal wastes**: [Bouncing](#) off fungus
- ❖ **Deepnest**: Peering through the darkness
- ❖ **Kingdom's edge**: High verticality
- ❖ **Royal waterways**: Lot of horizontal hallways

Hints, locks and keys:

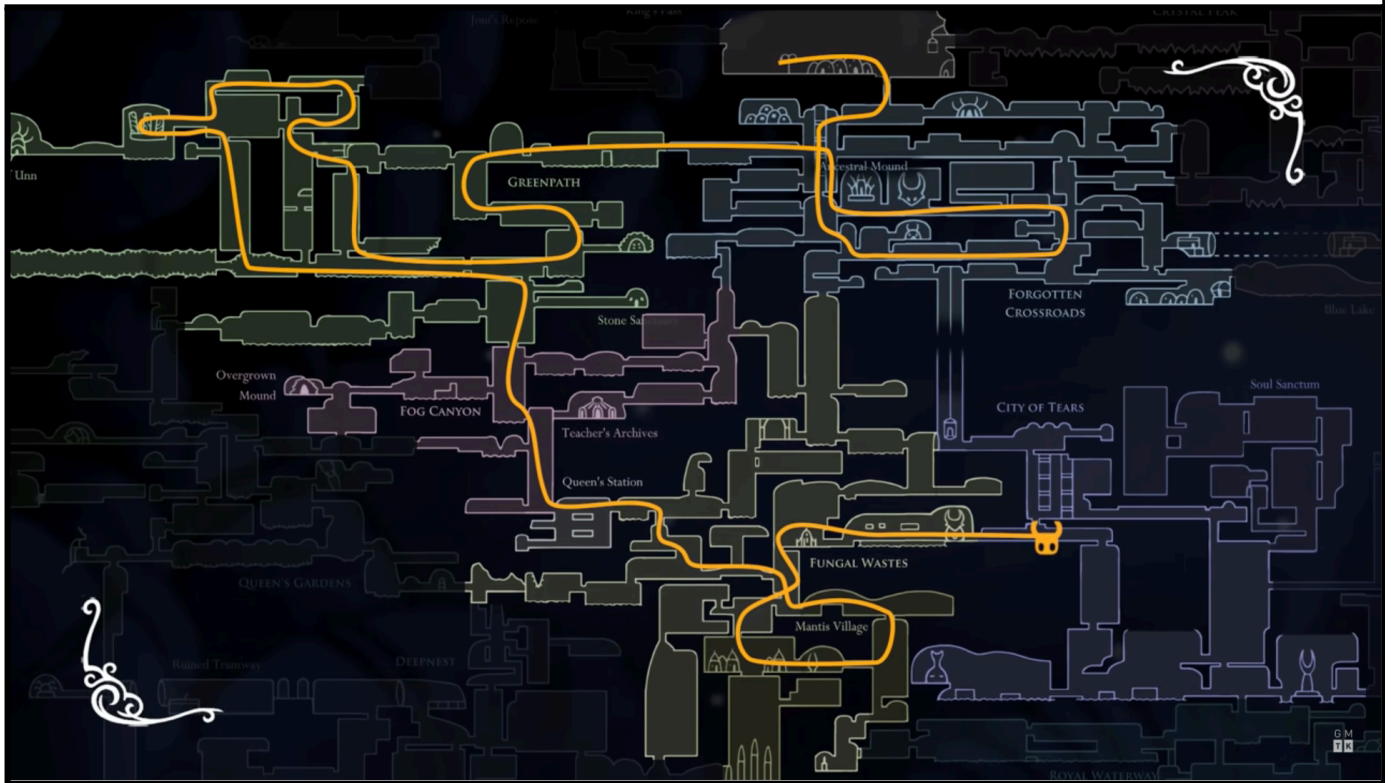
Rooms that connect different areas **share** some **aspects** with the other area: the connection with the Crossroads and Greenpath have leaves on the floor: teasing future content and telling where it's worth returning to.

The road to Greenpath is blocked by an [Elder Baldur](#). After obtaining the first spell, the [Vengeful Spirit](#), the game teaches the player how to use it against an Elder Baldur, **reminding** him to return to the road to Greenpath and begin the exploration of a new area.

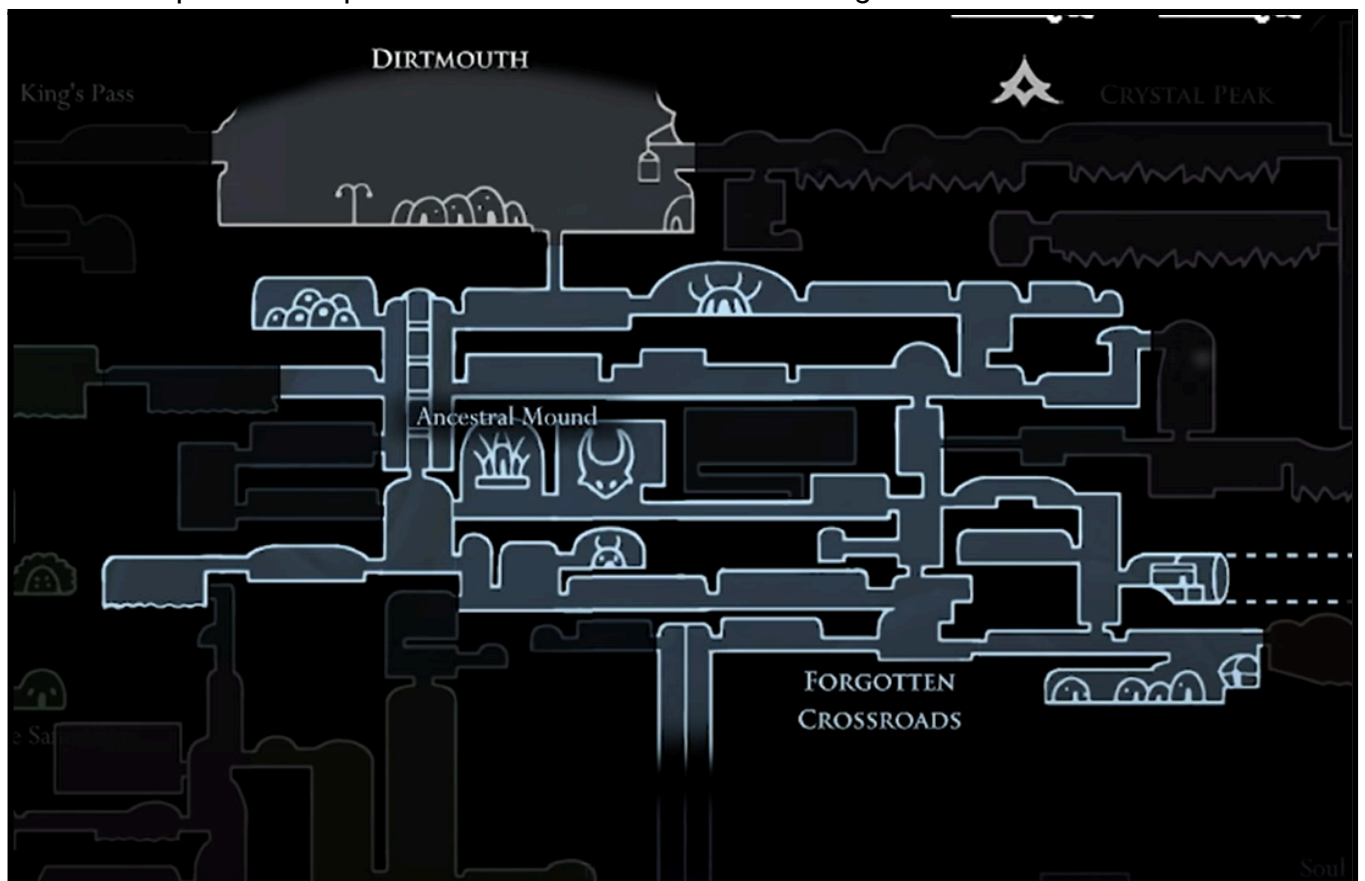
Linear beginning:

The game directs vaguely the player with [indications](#) and the movement of [Hornet](#), guiding him to an almost linear and direct path to the first three abilities:

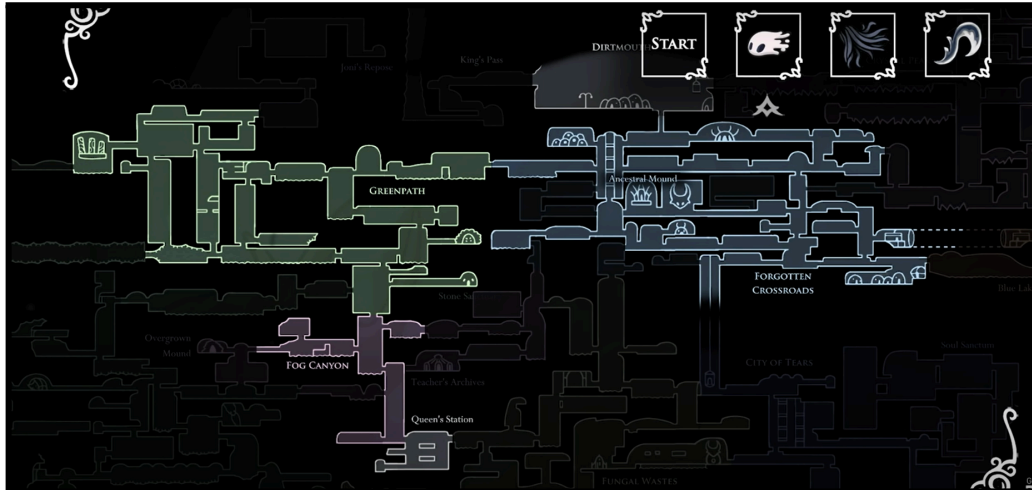
- ❖ Vengeful spirit
- ❖ [Mothwing cloak](#)
- ❖ [Mantis claw](#).



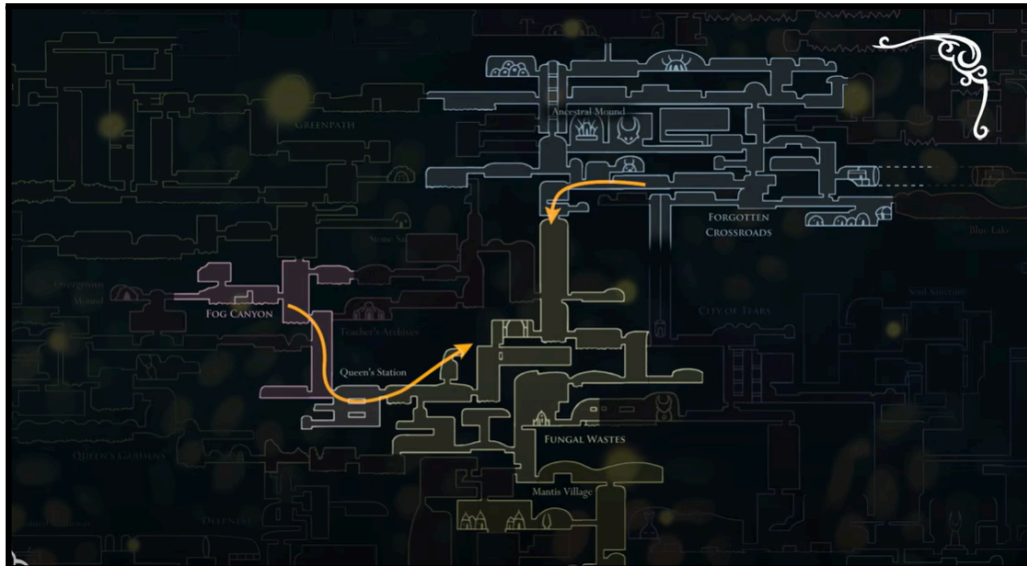
The initial explorable map is limited to Dirtmouth and the Forgotten Crossroads



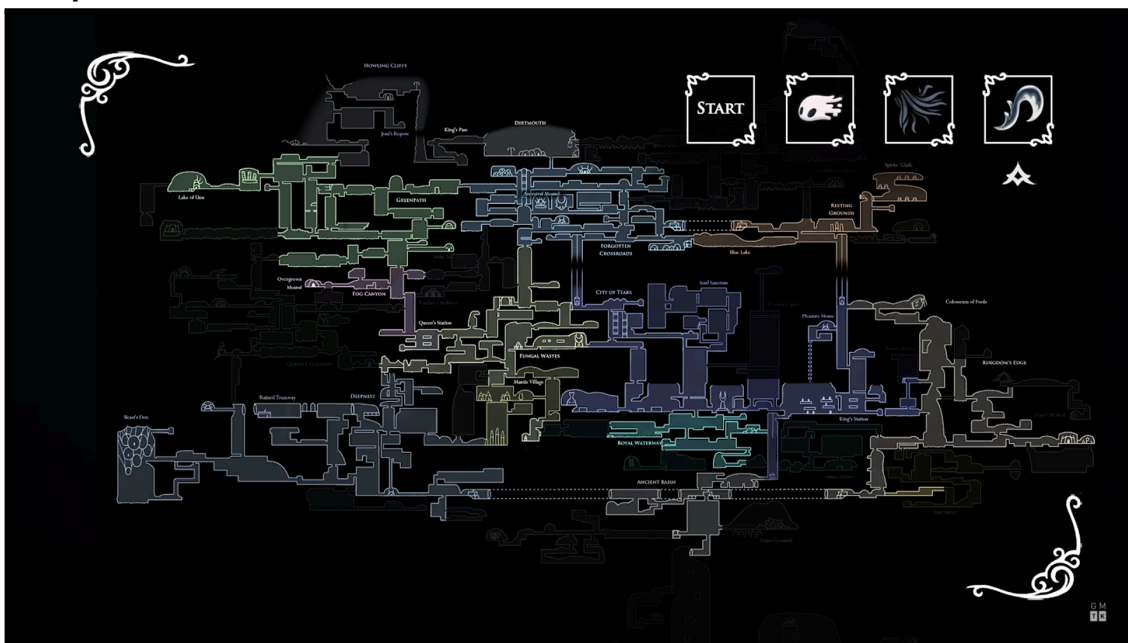
By **defeating the first boss**, the player has access to the Vengeful Spirit. Now he can kill the Elder Baldur and venture into Greenpath.



There, after **defeating Hornet**, she gives him the Mothwing Cloak that lets him reach the Fungal Wastes, in two different paths.



In the Mantis village lies the **Mantis Claw** that grants access to a lot of areas, making the game much more **open**.



“We started with a basic, linear progression of item acquirement, with the idea that we would allow that progression to break apart, branch out and wind around itself as the world grew”.

TEAM CHERRY

The player can explore 7 more areas, occasionally with another item needed (the [Tram pass](#) for example). But if he enters the City of Tears, a **gate is shut down** behind, forcing him to kill the [Soul Master](#) and gain the [Desolate Dive](#), for the only way out of the city is by using this ability. From this point on, the linearity of the map is completely gone.

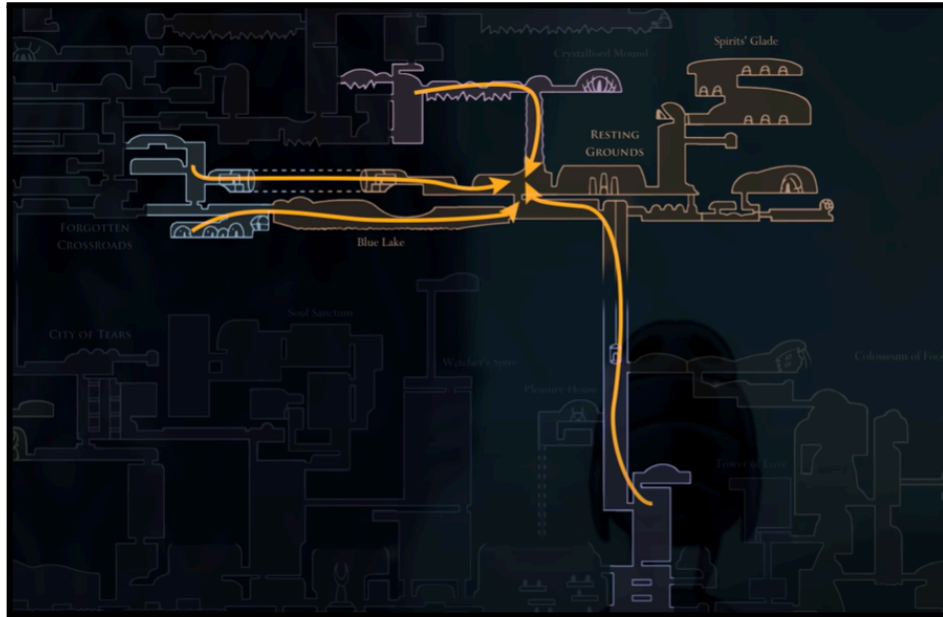
The player is pushed and rewarded for exploring with **different rewards**:

- ❖ Bosses (optional and non)
- ❖ Charms and upgrades.

Every area has **at least 2 ways to enter** it, avoiding the player being stuck.



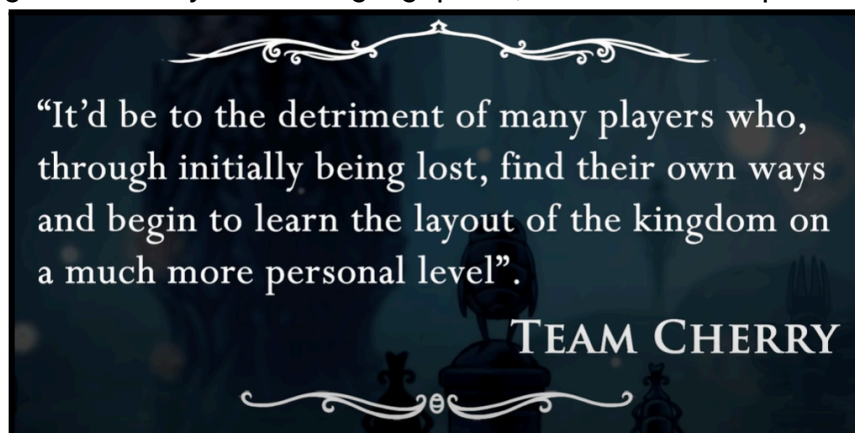
If he misses an entrance, he can still find the others. A great example to this is the **Resting Grounds**.



It's one of the most **important places** in the game, because **gives an actual goal to the player**: awaken the three Sentries:

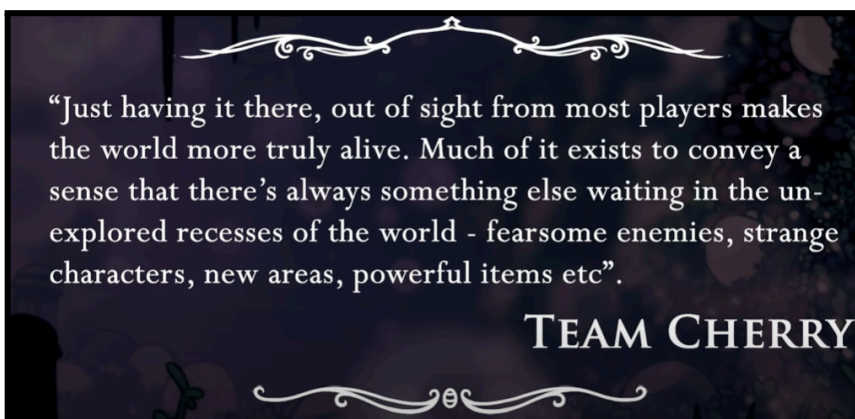
- ❖ **Herrah** the Beast
- ❖ **Lurien** the Watcher
- ❖ **Monomon** the Teacher

This allows the developers to be sure that the player will eventually find the Resting Grounds, without having to guide them by hand using signposts, directions or map markers.



Missable content:

Not every optional boss, item or upgrade is placed in a major area, and there are a lot of **secrets** that are easily missable:

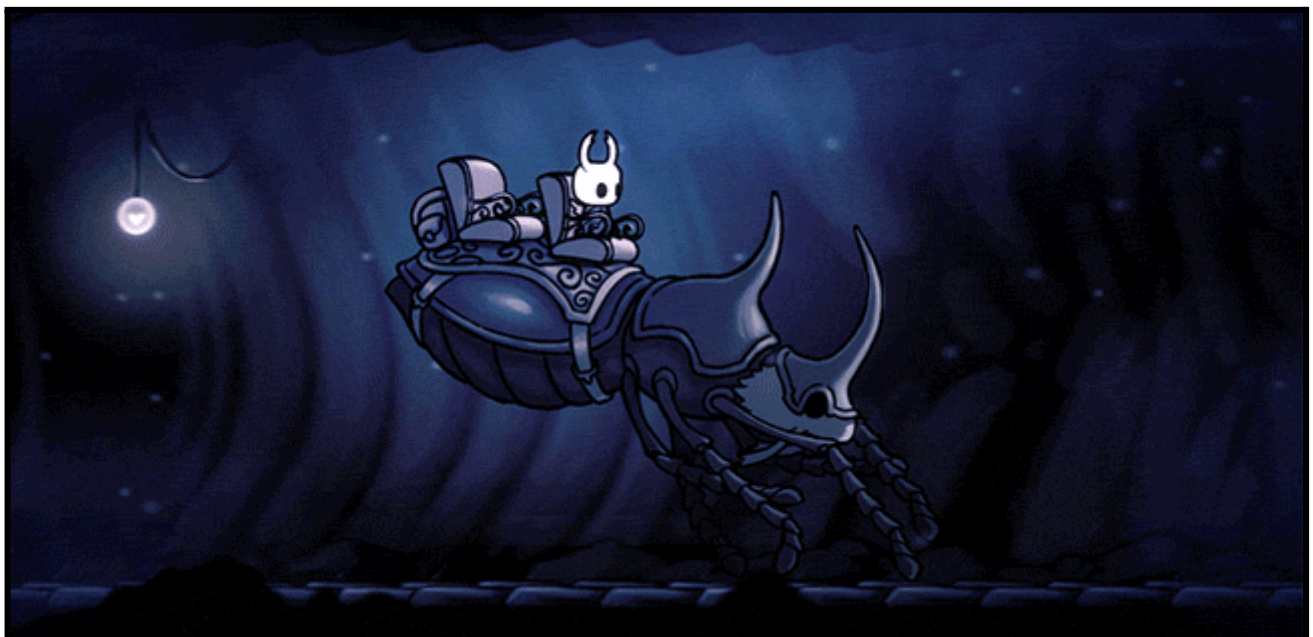


“And [it] creates a very special experience for those few that do make the discovery”.

TEAM CHERRY

Stags:

They function like teleports between areas. Cost Geo to unlock, then can be used at will. There are only **9** in the **15** areas, making sure that the player **won't just teleport in every area**, but still has to backtrack and explore walking.



Narrative



It begins with a mysterious knight arriving at Dirtmouth. The story and the quest of the character are **not told straight** by cinematic or dialogues, but are shown **little by little** with the environment, dialogues and objects.

In ancient times, the bugs of Hallownest worshipped a god called **Radiance**, that had the power to subdue the minds of everyone. Another great being came, The **Worm**, assuming the semblance of the **Pale King**, expanding the minds of all bugs and removing the memories of the Radiance, and created the kingdom of Hallownest.

Later, a statue of the Radiance was found and his memory came back, allowing him to spread the "**Infection**", driving all the bugs into madness. The Pale King created an empty vessel, a **Hollow Knight**, to contain the Infection, sealing it in the **Black Egg Temple**, with the help of three **Dreamers**. This method was a failure and the Infection could not be stopped.

The game has 3 endings:

- ❖ **Hollow knight**: The Knight defeat the Hollow knight and takes his place, though the infection still survives
- ❖ **Sealed siblings**: Similar to the first ending, but Hornet comes to help the Knight and is locked with him, becoming the Dreamer that locks the door.
- ❖ **Dream no more**: With the Dream Nail the Knight enters the Hollow knight's dreams and defeats Radiance ending the threat of the Infection, but the Knight disappears mysteriously.



User response

Positive responses:

- ❖ Very varied and detailed arts
- ❖ The exploration is highly rewarded with items, optional bosses and upgrades
- ❖ Interactive background
- ❖ Well balanced difficulty of the fights and a good learning curve
- ❖ Number of secrets and their placement

Negative responses:

- ❖ Clunky controls
- ❖ Harder platform sections
- ❖ Too much backtracking with low stimuli

Sources:

- ❖ Steam
- ❖ Gog
- ❖ [Metacritic](#)

Conclusions:

The **combat** feels boring because of the few attacks (special abilities are considered useless by many) but the difficulty of the bosses and the enemies is balanced and fair.

The **exploration** divides the users:

- ❖ Those who enjoyed it, exalt it because is full of secrets to reveal and every section of the map is highly differentiated from all the others
- ❖ Those who hated it, criticize it because of the absence of stimuli, considering the low numbers of teleports just an excuse to extend the duration of the game

Almost everyone, even the ones who disliked it, enjoyed the **art** and the **music**, considering them very fitting with the mood of the game and the characters.

The controls have one of the most negative reviews, even when played with a controller. They feel rough especially during the platform phases, mostly in the harder ones like the **Path of Pain** in the [White Palace](#).

Unique Selling Points

- ❖ Bug/Insect world setting
- ❖ Huge explorable world with interconnected areas
- ❖ Charm system

